Sovereign Grace

Sovereign Grace
© 2024 by Charlie Cornford
All rights reserved

Scripture quotations are from the ESV® Bible (The Holy Bible, English Standard Version®), © 2001 by Crossway, a publishing ministry of Good News Publishers. Used by permission. All rights reserved. The ESV text may not be quoted in any publication made available to the public by a Creative Commons license. The ESV may not be translated in whole or in part into any other language.

Table of Contents

1. Preface.....4
2. The gospel in plain language.....5
3. Unbelief.....14
4. The synergism of sanctification.....17
5. On pursuing holiness.....22
6. The Post-Modern bible study.....25
7. Did Gerry love Kate?.....30
8. What is the gospel?.....33
9. How free is free?.....36
10. Covid-19: A Christian perspective.....38
11. Are natural disasters God's judgement upon sinners?.....41
12. Whatever happened to repentance?.....45
13. Being special to God.....48
14. The catastrophic consequences of Universal Atonement...53
15. Election.....58
16. Overcoming the sinful nature.....60
17. Reconciling a gracious God with an eternal hell.....63

1. Preface

The material presented in this book is a collection of posts mostly submitted to Facebook over recent years of matters that surfaced in a weekly bible study which I have had the privilege of leading. The topics are not ordered in any logical manner but are presented in the order in which they arose. They are, in my opinion, topics that are likely to arise in other bible studies, especially those which touch on the matter of sovereign grace and Reformed theology in general. So it seemed a good idea to put them together into a single book for future study in their own right.

Most of the references are made to scripture and not to commentators or theologians. It is my belief that scriptural proof is a necessary and sufficient condition to verify any proposition given in this type of material. My doctrine of scripture is that of verbal and plenary inspiration, completely inerrant and perspicuous in respect to the gospel of salvation. My preferred translation is the English Standard Version which I have used exclusively throughout this book.

The book does not try to be politically correct. I believe that its content is agreeable to the confessional standards of the mainline Reformed/Presbyterian Churches and does not seek to say anything new in respect to theology. But it does try to explain some of the more difficult concepts that can be a source of vexation to students of Reformed theology, particularly those who are new to that tradition.

So in the words of Jesus in Matthew 7:7, "Seek and you will find". Happy seeking!

2. The gospel in plain language

If you are reading this chapter because you would like to become a Christian then you need to understand that you cannot make yourself a Christian. Only God can do that (John 3:1-8). That is not to say that you don't have to do anything to become a Christian; far be it! But if you did take the requisite steps it would be because God enabled you to take them in the first place; more than that, he drew you irresistibly to Jesus Christ – you could do no other (John 6:44).

So what does it mean to become a Christian. Let's start with what it isn't:

1. It is not a decision to adopt a certain lifestyle or philosophical stance. In other words, Christianity is not an ideology. It is essentially a matter of the heart and you cannot change your heart.
2. It is not a decision to win God's approval so as to benefit from his generosity. We can never "win" God's approval. The bible is clear on that.
3. It is not simply joining an organisation such as a church. The devil can do that!
4. It is not submitting to certain rituals such as baptism. The world is riddled with people who were baptised as infants and yet have never darkened a church door in their lives.
5. It is not donating large sums of money to a church or a worthy cause. God doesn't want your money, he has plenty of his own.
6. It is not saying prayers every day. Until we are Christians God doesn't even hear our prayers.

7. It is not accepting some verbal mantra such as "Jesus has died for your sins" or "God loves you and has a wonderful plan for your life", neither of which is true for most people.
8. It is not believing that God exists. The devil not only believes God exists but he actually KNOWS God exists, and that doesn't do him any good.

The above list is not exhaustive but probably covers most of the misunderstandings that people have about what it means to be or become a Christian. So how do people become Christians? There are many things that can be said but I want to answer the question by defining what is the absolutely central and most important aspect of true conversion and that is:

BECOMING A CHRISTIAN IS TO BE RECONCILED TO GOD.

Becoming a Christian is to address the most pressing and life shattering problem any man or woman can possibly have in this life. It is to address the problem of alienation between ourselves and God. This alienation is not just on our part but also on God's. Prior to conversion we want nothing to do with God. We might think we do but the bible is clear that we don't (Romans 1:18-32). If we think we love God then we don't know him; it's as simple as that. In fact we spend our lives suppressing the truth about God which is evident all around us. We invent stories to remove God from anything that might even remotely suggest his existence. The common one in the west is Darwinian Evolution. In the east it is animism, paganism and all the other isms that try to explain the universe in godless terms.

So how did we get to have this condition? Unfortunately we were born with it (John 3:1-8; Romans 5:12-21). We got it from our parents, who got it from their parents, and so on. It goes right back to the first couple from whom the entire human race is descended. The male of this couple did not merely act on his own behalf but on behalf of his entire progeny. Yes, power of attorney is as old as Adam. This couple, and more importantly the man, loused up catastrophically when they disobeyed God after being placed in a beautiful garden with everything they needed. And the guilt of their sin passed on to all of their descendants. And not only their guilt but also their sinful nature, ie., a nature that sins naturally with no premeditation required.

Christianity addresses the problem of the inherited guilt and sinful nature of man. In so doing it reconciles us to God so that God changes from foe to friend. Although Christianity is essentially a matter of the heart there is an intellectual component, i.e., there are things we must believe in order to cross the threshold. This essay won't do you any good unless you believe it. And to believe it you must be born again, i.e., born of God. This is called regeneration. If you have not been regenerated it is unlikely that you would have read this far so be encouraged, you are heading in the right direction.

When the Holy Spirit regenerates a sinner the sinner has no say in it. He/she is completely passive. The circumstances of regeneration are irrelevant to the process. You could be in the middle of robbing a bank or committing genocide but the change becomes evident when you are convicted of your wrong doing. But this conviction is not just the realisation that you have done the wrong thing but that you have sinned

AGAINST GOD. This distinguishes the conviction of regeneration from every other type of conviction. It is the conviction that you are a rebel against God and you are decidedly uncomfortable about it.

You might be thinking: but I'm not that bad, am I? Yes you are. What matters is not how you appear to yourself but how you appear to God for it is God who determines your ultimate destiny. So let's turn to some biblical passages to see just how God sees you right now.

Romans 3:10-18

> What then? Are we Jews any better off? No, not at all. For we have already charged that all, both Jews and Greeks, are under sin, as it is written: “None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks for God. All have turned aside; together they have become worthless; no one does good, not even one.” “Their throat is an open grave; they use their tongues to deceive.” “The venom of asps is under their lips.” “Their mouth is full of curses and bitterness.” “Their feet are swift to shed blood; in their paths are ruin and misery, and the way of peace they have not known.” “There is no fear of God before their eyes.”

So who is Paul talking about here? The expression "Jews and Greeks" means Jews and non-Jews, which is everybody. Many people don't agree with the judgements of our legal system but the legal system wins every time. It is the same with God

except even more so. God's judgements are always correct and Romans 3:10-18 is about you.

John 3:19-20

> And this is the judgement: the light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light because their works were evil. For everyone who does wicked things hates the light and does not come to the light, lest his works should be exposed.

Here, Jesus is the "light" and John 3:19-20 is a description of the response all unregenerate people make to the gospel.

Ephesians 2:1-3

> And you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience—among whom we all once lived in the passions of our flesh, carrying out the desires of the body and the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, like the rest of mankind.

In this passage the apostle Paul is describing the Ephesian church before they were converted. Were they a particularly wicked bunch? No, they were just ordinary unregenerate people getting on with their lives. So when it comes to God's view of the unbelieving world his descriptions are not about

bolstering egos. But the pathway to conversion always includes a realisation on our part that his judgements are true. This is the effect of being born again of the Holy Spirit.

The next thing we need to consider is what you can do about this condition of sin. I said at the beginning that you cannot make yourself a Christian but there are still things you have to do which the Holy Spirit enables you to do by changing your heart. Having considered the bad news we now take a look at the good news of the gospel which is summarised for us in John 3:16.

> For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.

John 3:16 is about God's love, and in particular, how God loves the world. To see this love we have to look in the right place, and the place to look is the events of the gospel itself. So God loves the world in this way, that he has given his only begotten Son, who is Jesus Christ. And the purpose of this gift is that the world should not perish but have eternal life. Many doubt the love of God because they look in all the wrong places. We don't see God's love in our circumstances because our circumstances are a mixed bag. In that bag are the good and the bad. Sadness stains every part of life from infant mortality to war and genocide. We have good days and we have bad days. The best we get from all of this is ambiguity, certainly nothing clear about God's love.

The giving of the Son amounts to a rescue mission; we are rescued from the end result of being at enmity with God: we perish. Don't confuse this with annihilation; it is closer to dying from a thousand cuts except that we never actually die. It is, in short, eternal hell. Jesus has more to say about hell than anyone else in the bible. The unregenerate end up there because there is no place for them in heaven. Heaven is a place where there is no sin or any of its consequences and the bible knows of no third alternative. Furthermore, hell is also a place of punishment for sin which never ends because its occupants never repent.

In the gospel we see God entering into the suffering of man by his own death upon a cross; so God did not exempt himself from that suffering which was necessary in order to pay the penalty that was incurred by sinners. On the cross Jesus took their place and suffered on their behalf. When someone sacrifices his own life to save another we cannot doubt the motive for that sacrifice; indeed, Jesus tells us in John 15:13, "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends." We call this the supreme sacrifice.

So while John 3:16 teaches us the how of God's love, John 15:13 teaches us the extent of that love. But now we must add an important qualification. It is not everybody who benefits from that love but only those who believe in him. In other words, the incomprehensible saving love of God is found only in the Son. To be beneficiaries of that love we need to be united to Jesus, a union that is acquired by faith. This faith is a

wholehearted trust in Jesus Christ to take away our sin, thereby saving us from the judicial consequences of our sin and making us friends of God for ever. This is the reconciliation spoken of earlier in this tract and it is called "eternal life". It is life in all its intended fullness and it is eternal for it never ends, transcending physical death.

Can we trust Jesus to take away our sin and give us eternal life? Approximately 2000 years ago Jesus was crucified by the Romans and died an agonising death. We know he died because he was embalmed and buried in a rich man's tomb. But on the third day after his death Jesus raised himself from the grave (Luke 24). So how does a dead man raise himself? Clearly, there had to be something more to Jesus than a human nature, i.e., another source of power. We know from the many miracles that Jesus performed throughout his earthly ministry that he had the supernatural power of God. He raised others from the dead, healed lepers, restored sight to the blind, made paralytics walk, controlled the weather, multiplied bread and fish, walked on water and turned water into wine. All of these miracles are recorded in the gospels of the New Testament. But the final and definitive miracle of all was to raise himself from the dead. This proved that he had two natures: a human nature and a divine nature. It was his divine nature that raised the human nature from the dead and it will be this same divine nature that will raise his people from the dead at his return.

So you must ask yourself: just who is Jesus and can I trust him to take my sin away and give me eternal life? If your first

answer is the God-man and your second is "Yes" then congratulations, you have been born again of the Holy Spirit. Now put your trust wholly in Jesus to remove your sin and submit to him as Lord and master and he will put his Holy Spirit inside you to comfort and strengthen you.

Finally, it is important that you attach yourself to a Christ-centred church where the bible is preached faithfully and where the people have done what you have done - put their faith in Jesus as their Lord and Saviour. The New Testament knows nothing of churchless Christians for it is the means that God has appointed by which we are to grow spiritually. And may God go with you. Amen.

3. Unbelief

Unbelief is like a man who was driving in the country until he came to a T junction unsignposted. There was a traffic warden standing at the junction. The driver pulled over and walked over to the traffic warden. The warden told him that if he turned left he would come to a city in a valley that, for some reason, got very little sunlight. Its citizens were very unhappy and there was often the sounds of wailing and gnashing of teeth.

If he turned right he would come to a city on a hill where it was always sunny. Those who lived there were always happy and often sang and danced in the streets. Naturally the driver decided to turn right and head for the city of light but as he was about to make the turn the traffic warden stopped him. "I need to tell you something more about the city of light" he said. "God lives there". The driver quickly turned left and drove off.
So what does this story tell us about unbelief? (John 3:19-21; 3:16)

If you tried answering the question you might have turned to John 3:19-21 where we are told that people “hate the light and will not come to the light”. What is this light? Clearly it is Jesus who has “come into the world” (V.19). He managed to keep his head down for 30 years and then raised his profile for another three. That’s all it took to get himself nailed to a cross. And I know what you’re thinking, “If I had been there I would have accepted Jesus”. Really?

How carefully do you guard your self-esteem or how good would you rate yourself on a scale from 1 – 10? After being with Jesus for only a short time the apostle Peter could say to Jesus “Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord” (Luke 5:8). Peter’s self-esteem went through the floor after meeting Jesus.

Until there is a radical intervention of God into our hearts even the very thought of being in God’s presence makes us cringe. Here nothing is private; all is exposed for what it is right down to our innermost thoughts and desires (Hebrews 4:12). Let’s be honest, if God is like that then who wants him? Who wouldn’t prefer darkness and the sound of wailing and gnashing of teeth? If He were not so perfect and didn’t know absolutely everything about us then perhaps we could tolerate him in small doses. But to know us through and through so extensively and intensively, is more than we can bear.

I mentioned earlier the need for a radical intervention by God into our hearts because the problem we are talking about is a deep and abiding hostility toward God himself that exists in all of us. This hostility does not take the form of a fist shaking anger necessarily but mostly a cold rejection, of not wanting anything to do with God. This all started in the Garden of Eden when Adam ignored God’s direction not to eat from a certain tree and then made himself scarce so that God had to (anthropomorphically) look for him. This is now the condition of Adam’s posterity.

So how is this deep and abiding hostility overcome? The answer to this question is given to us in John 3:1-15. The salient points of this passage are:

1. We have a need for a change so radical that it compares only to a complete restart in life. We must be “born again”, says Jesus.
2. The agent of this rebirth is the Holy Spirit, the third person of the Trinity. This makes the entire process supernatural.
3. Our role in this transformation is as passive as that of a newborn. We contribute nothing to it.
4. Spiritual rebirth (regeneration) is the condition that must be met before anyone can be reconciled to God. This makes it chronologically prior to entering his kingdom.
5. The result of regeneration is a painful awareness of our sin and a desire to be reconciled to God.
6. It is at this point that the gospel comes to our rescue and we read that in John 3:14-17.

The change described above is not made in a vacuum for God sees to it that the regenerate are also made aware of the good news of Jesus Christ, and in particular, his redeeming work on the cross. We embrace his offer of salvation from sin and its judicial consequences and we spend the rest of our lives growing in our knowledge of God. This makes us God lovers.
So where do you fit in this theological paradigm?

4. The synergism of sanctification

In the previous chapters we saw how regeneration is a sovereign work of the Holy Spirit. In this work we are totally passive just as a baby is passive throughout the birthing process. Just as we don't birth ourselves when we come into the world, neither do we birth ourselves when we come into spiritual life.

We also saw that once regeneration takes place, faith and repentance follow by the hearing of the gospel. This is our entrance into the kingdom of God and we enter as new born babes. And just as babies need to grow physically so we need to grow spiritually which process is called *sanctification*.

Unlike regeneration, which is a monergism, i.e., a work of the Holy Spirit alone, sanctification is what we call a synergism. A synergism is a work of two or more agents and in the case of sanctification the Holy Spirit works with us to build us up to a state of spiritual maturity. Leaving out either one of these agents would bring sanctification to a complete halt.

So if we did nothing, i.e., never went to church, never read the bible, never prayed, never listened to a sermon or sang a hymn, we would never grow. I think even a cursory glance at the scriptures, especially the New Testament, makes that abundantly clear. In Philippians 2:12-13 we read,

> 12 Therefore, my beloved, as you have always obeyed, so now, not only as in my presence but

> much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling, 13 for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure.

Here we see the synergism of sanctification defined in terms of God the Holy Spirit working in us and we ourselves working out what he works in. This "working out" is no mindless activity but requires understanding, i.e., a diligent application of the scriptures. But if, after having read the scriptures or having listened to a sermon we gain no understanding whatsoever, would we be sanctified anyway? Paul makes it equally clear from 1 Corinthians 14 that such mindless activity profits us nothing. So any kind of religious activity whether it happens to be the Lord’s Supper, or baptism or anything else we care to do in the name of sanctification that is not coupled with understanding is a total waste of time. This is in stark contrast with the Roman Catholic view which states that a simple cooperation with the church is sufficient for spiritual growth, a process referred to as ‘ex opere operato’ - from the work, worked. But the reformers rejected this idea insisting on understanding as an essential requisite for true sanctification. This is a dynamic worth exploring a little more deeply.

We could define sanctification as a two step process: 1. Getting the word into the mind; 2. Getting the word from the mind to the heart.

WORD -> MIND -> HEART

The Christian puts the Word of God into the mind. There is nothing supernatural about this and involves reading or hearing the word of God *with understanding*.

So far so good. We have the natural leg of a two-legged process. Even non-Christians can traverse this leg. But true sanctification has not taken place until the second leg is taken. The second leg is where the Holy Spirit takes what is in the mind and puts it into the heart. This is a supernatural process and is what we call sanctification proper (Jeremiah 31:31-34). It is the Word of God firmly implanted in the heart that brings about the fruits of the Holy Spirit (Galatians 5:22-23).

So how can we be sure that we are being truly sanctified? We need to run the following tests:

1. Are we getting the Word of God? Are we hearing it preached faithfully? Are we reading it regularly?

2. Do we understand the word? This may take effort and is the seeking that God wants us to do in Matt. 7:7.

3. Does it increase our love for God and our desire to please him?

4. Is this knowledge and love translating into fruit? Is there enough evidence in my life to convict me of being a Christian if I were charged with being one. What’s different about me from unbelievers?

In 1 Corinthians 14 the apostle Paul makes it abundantly clear that the whole purpose of the public assemblies of the church is edification; indeed, this word appears no less than seven times in this chapter, and is a synonym for sanctification.

We can deduce therefore that whatever helps us take the Word to Mind step will enable the Holy Spirit to take the Mind to Heart step. This means that the hymns we sing, the scriptures we read, and the sermons we hear should all contribute to this first step of the process. If they don't then we are wasting our time. This means that we must examine the content and quality of the hymns we sing. Are they based on the Word of God? Do they have a didactic quality? (Colossians 3:16). Or to put this more simply: what does this hymn teach me about God and how does it help me love him more?

When it comes to the sermon the same questions apply. Clearly a sermon can never contribute to our sanctification if it is not based upon the Word of God (Remember, the first leg is Word to Mind). Also required by the first leg is understanding. This means that the Word must be explained and applied. Nobody said this would be easy for the preacher but it does say something about how the preacher should be spending most of his time throughout the week.

Finally there is the Christian's private devotional time. It is hard to imagine that a Christian would undergo much sanctification if limited to a 30 minute sermon on Sundays. How successful would the schools be if they tried to cover a week's work in one 30 minute period? "Ah", you might say, "but schools equip children for life." True! But the word of God equips God's people for *eternal* life So we should be

grappling with the Word of God by any means possible. This might include the reading of scripture or books about scripture, listening to sermon pod-casts and benefiting from the insights of other Christians while always using the quality tests described above.

In closing, don’t let an anti-intellectual approach to the bible rob you of the transformative knowledge of God. Remember how John defines eternal life, “And this is eternal life, that they know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent” (John 17:3). Happy seeking!

5. On pursuing holiness

In 1 John 1:8-10 we learn the bitter truth that the Christian will never be done with sin while he continues at home in the body. No matter how hard he tries to overcome it sin will continue to rear its ugly head until he takes his final breath.

So how should we deal with sin? If we understand the anatomy of temptation we will know that our ability to resist is dependent upon the strength of our love for God. According to the principle of opposing forces, the love of God must trump the force of attraction to commit sin. So a good strategy in overcoming sin is to strengthen the former as much as we can so that we can resist the latter. Another factor in sin is the force of habit. Much human behaviour is habitual and requires a good deal of practice in acquiring new habits. But again, we will only make the effort to do this if we love God enough.

In overcoming sin it is a good idea to do a postmortem to find out precisely why we sinned and how we can avoid that sin in the future. This might mean avoiding certain situations such as places or even people who tempt us to sin. But, as previously pointed out, the bottom line to sin is that we commit it because we simply don’t love God enough. This brings us back to the subject of sanctification. Sanctification, if you remember, is the strengthening of our love for God which will only happen as we get to know Him better.

A defining characteristic of all Christians is that they love God and want to be like him. No Christian is satisfied with this. All Christians want to love God more; it’s just that some want that

more than others. So just how big a part of our lives should this "want" be? We could ask this question another way: Where on the totem pole of priorities should our love for God be? I think we can all agree that it should be at the very top; after all, we are to love God with *all* our hearts and with *all* our souls, with *all* our strength and with *all* our minds (Luke 10:27). This takes our relationship with God out of the back stalls and places it centre stage. Here it beats our job, our possessions, our status, our health, and even our earthly relationships. And if we are really serious about this it will also take a big chunk of our time. Loving God to any great extent does not come easily. It is something we have to pursue; it won't come to us. We must wrestle with God in prayer for it. We must hunger and thirst for it. We must cry out to God for it. We must be obsessed with getting it – literally!

Is this going too far? Some would say "yes", but the logic is so compelling and there is so much scripture that supports it. Take, for example, Matthew 6:33, "But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you." I once applied for a job in town as a computer programmer. I was asked why I wanted the job. I replied, in broad terms, that I wanted to work honestly with my own hands so that I would not be a burden to tax payers and to provide for my family (Ephesians 4:28). I knew from the interviewer's face that I had just signed my own death warrant. The "right" answer was that I loved programming and I wanted to make a difference to the world by creating good software. As true as that might have been it wasn't my principal motivation.

In closing, as Christians we need to get serious with God. So much Christianity is "on the side" as it were. Having said that,

please don’t get the impression that my faith is always centre stage because it isn’t. I find myself straying because of sheer lack of diligence. Distraction is probably the biggest enemy of sanctification. We get caught up with other pursuits and they encroach on the only pursuit that really matters, the pursuit of holiness. But sanctification should also be a community effort where we bear one another’s burdens. Thank God for churches, as imperfect as they are, for if they are Christ-centred they can be factories of spiritual giants and we neglect them at our own peril.

6. The Post-Modern bible study

In our pursuit of holiness we need to be aware that there are activities we can engage in which do little to achieve growth in grace. One of these activities is what I call the post-modern bible study. We will start with a fairly typical but slightly exaggerated example and then move to an explanation of why such an approach is not spiritually helpful to its participants.

Frank (Study leader but not the pastor): “Welcome all to the bible study for tonight. Our bible text for this evening is John 3:16 and I trust that you have all given some thought to this passage before coming tonight. Malcolm, would you like to read John 3:16 for us before we begin?

Malcolm: “Certainly Frank, “For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life”.

Frank: “Thanks Malcolm. So let’s begin our study and I would like Sandra to tell us what John 3:16 means to her”.

Sandra: “Well, after reading this verse at home I get the distinct impression that it’s about God’s love for the Earth and what a precious place it is. And if God loves the earth this much then we need to love it as well which means that we need to care about the environment. We Christians need to be at the forefront in trying to cut back on Carbon emissions and keeping our rivers free of pollutants. That’s what John 3:16 means to me”.

Frank: “Thanks Sandra. I’m glad that the Spirit has spoken to your heart about this and I’m sure you have given us all food for thought. Now, perhaps Malcolm can tell us what John 3:16 means to him”.

Malcolm: “Well, I get the distinct impression that John 3:16 is about the indiscriminate love of God for everyone despite their creed or colour. It says to me that we need to be as inclusive as God is and not to shut anyone out of the church if they wish to join. We also need to accept other religions as sincere attempts to know God and not push our own as the only correct view”.

Frank: “Well done Malcolm, and thanks for the unique insight. Now we come to Diane”.

Diane: “My feeling is that John 3:16 is about family values; after all, it is about God the Father sending his Son to save the world. How many parents would trust their children to do a job like that? I teach my children that they can be anything they want and to have good self esteem”.

Frank: “Now that’s a novel view Diane! What a rich variety of interpretations we have heard so far tonight. We have certainly given each other something to think about.

It is pretty obvious, I think, that there are serious errors in the various interpretations of John 3:16 given by the participants of this study. Oddly enough though, the real problem with this study is not in the interpretations, as erroneous as they are, but

in something far more serious and even deadly in its effect upon the modern Christian’s ability to know God.

So what is postmodernism? To put it as simply as possible, postmodernism is a philosophical movement of the mid to late 20th century which reacted to the idea of truth as something objective and independent of the knower (Modernism). The postmodernist concept of truth is something quite subjective, a construction of the knower within the terms of his/her cultural, ethnic and linguistic milieu. This makes everyone’s opinion as good as anyone else’s since nobody really knows the objective truth anyway.

Although there is much more to postmodernism which we don't have time for here, it is the epistomology of postmodernism (how we know anything) that is the focus of our concern here and where postmodernism has had the most impact upon the churches. Armed with this piece of information we are now in a position to see how much that masquerades as “bible study” is really not bible study at all but a pooling of ignorance designed to make people feel good about themselves and their own ideas.

The first thing we notice is that the study leader is not the pastor. This doesn’t mean that other Christians in the congregation cannot teach biblical truth but, in most cases, the best person to teach that truth is the one who is trained to do so, i.e., the pastor; after all, that is his job. But if the study is a pooling of personal opinions all of which are taken as equally valid then we don’t need a bible expert. All we need is a chairman with good people skills. And that’s what we have in Frank.

The second thing we notice is that people are asked what John 3:16 means “to them”. This is a very different question to what it actually “means”. The latter presupposes that there is a single, unambiguous and objective meaning which people either get or they don’t. But that will never do in a PM bible study. Instead they are asked to give their own subjective take on the text, determined by their own personal agenda. So to Sandra John 3:16 is all about the environment, to Malcolm its all about inclusiveness and to Diane its all about family values. Frank brings nothing to the table other than his scintillating personality, which is entirely consistent with the PM approach – he is the chairman or facilitator, but he is NOT the teacher.

So what’s wrong with all of that; after all, a good time was had by all wasn’t it? Let me enumerate the problems:

1. Truth is not subjective but very objective; neither is it something we construct out of our own personal agenda or cultural milieu. When God speaks he speaks the objective truth and if we don’t get it right we get it wrong. It is not ambiguous or self contradictory; neither does it change from one generation to another.

2. The bible is the Word of God to man and is therefore knowable to man. God is no obscurantist. This doesn’t mean that it is all equally easy to understand which is why we have pastors who are trained in the science of hermeneutics and exegesis. It is no small error to choose ignorant men to lead bible studies.

3. It is not true that everybody's "take" on the truth is correct. People can can get it wrong and often do. And when they are wrong they need to be corrected and be humble enough to take that correction. It is not unloving to do this; on the contrary, it is quite unloving to allow people to miss the important saving message of John 3:16.

4. The aim of any bible study that's worth its salt is to get to know God better from his word; it is not to generate good feelings. The apostle Paul's charge to Timothy is very clear: "preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching" (2 Timothy 4:2).

So what should you do if you find yourself attending a PM bible study? You need to talk to your church leaders, pointing out the problems. Don't take this lying down; after all, PM bible studies are at best a waste of time and at worst a gospel sellout. Remember, you don't want to know what the passage means to this person or that person; you just want to know what it means. And in most cases your pastor is the best person to tell you this. Like holiness, getting to know God is a pursuit. It is HARD WORK! But oh so rewarding!

7. Did Gerry love Kate?

After 20 years of marriage Kate couldn't make up her mind whether Gerry, her husband, really loved her. Although Gerry worked hard to support his family to a high standard he also had some pretty glaring faults. He rarely told Kate that he loved her and wasn't very affectionate toward her. He mostly remembered their anniversary but not always. Sometimes he even forgot her birthday and if it wasn't for Kate the kids would have missed out as well. But then, Gerry did spend time with his kids; perhaps not enough for Kate, but enough to cultivate a relationship with them.

One day when the kids were at school Gerry got a phone call from his neighbour to say that his house was on fire and that he needed to return home immediately. When Jerry arrived home he saw smoke billowing out of the windows of his house and could hear the faint cry of his wife begging for help. The fire brigade told him to stand back as there was nothing he could do but Gerry ignored their advice, grabbed a respirator from the fire truck and rushed into the house despite protests from the firefighters.

He found Kate lying on the kitchen floor and immediately removed the respirator from his own mouth and applied it to hers. He managed to carry Kate to the nearest window and lowered her to the ground using his trouser belt. Kate recovered but unfortunately Gerry was overcome by smoke and perished in the fire.

So to return to the question: did Jerry love Kate? How we answer this question depends on where we look. If we focus on the first paragraph we, like Kate, would be hard pressed to answer the question at all; after all, sometimes Gerry got it right and other times he got it wrong. At best we have ambiguity here. And if that's where the story ended we would probably say, with Kate, that we don't know either. But fortunately there is more to the story and the second paragraph gives us a very clear and unambiguous expression of love that is hard for even the most hardened sceptic to deny. Gerry sacrifices his life for Kate. It is not as though Jerry did not consider the dangers; he was warned by the firefighters and in the smoke filled kitchen he actually transferred the respirator from his own face to Kate's.

So what does the bible say about this? In John 15:13 we read the following words of the Lord Jesus Christ: "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends." In saying this Jesus was preparing his disciples for his crucifixion as proof that his love for them was incontestable. And if Jesus' death proves his love for us then so does Jerry's death prove his love for Kate. To doubt one is to cast a shadow over the other.

So what of the ambiguity in Jerry's love prior to the fire? Is there a parallel here too? Let's consider it. When we think about the ups and downs of the Christian life we too can become doubtful about the love of God for us. We are victims of injustice, natural disaster, disease, persecution, misunderstanding, accidents …the list goes on. We are certainly not immune from affliction. And if we were to limit ourselves to providence as the only source of knowledge of

God's love we would be understandably confused. But fortunately God has not left us without a clear and certain knowledge for we know from the gospel that Jesus died a painful death that we might live. And that is where we must fix our gaze.

I am certain that when Kate spoke of Jerry in the years following his death his supreme sacrifice for her would have eclipsed the ambiguities in his previous life. And let me assure you that the more we get to know the unfathomable love of Christ crucified for us, so too will the ambiguities of this life pale ever so faintly into the background of our personal testimony.

We will close with the words of the apostle Paul: "For I determined to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ, and Him crucified." (1 Corinthians 2:2)

8. What is the gospel?

Do evangelicals agree on what is the gospel? We might disagree on baptism and church government and eschatology but one would think that we would be united on the gospel and particularly the belief in salvation by grace through faith alone. In my travels over the past couple of years since my retirement I have had the opportunity of visiting a range of different evangelical denominations and in so doing I have been left with the distinct impression that while we all might agree on what constitutes a Christian we certainly don't agree on the method of getting there.

One way to explain the gospel is to start at the end and work our way back to the beginning, i.e., the point of unbelief. So let's start with a different question: what is a Christian? A Christian is someone who has been reconciled to God, is no longer at enmity with God and now has faith in Jesus Christ for salvation from sin and its judicial consequences.

We know from Paul's letter to the Galatians that saving faith is a trusting in Christ ALONE for salvation. When the judaizers tried to add circumcision to the gospel as a condition for salvation Paul branded it as another gospel altogether. To add works of the law to faith, says Paul, is to destroy grace and to land ourselves in the barren wasteland of legalism (Galatians 1-3).

The second component of faith is knowledge. We cannot put faith exclusively in Christ to save us if we don't know who we are trusting. Faith is not a leap in the dark but an intelligent

trust in a person who is trustworthy and able to deliver what he promises. So we have to know enough about Jesus to do this intelligently (John 17:3)

The third component of faith is our consent to the truth of the gospel. We have to agree with it. This is not something we can force on another and is completely up to the Holy Spirit to bring about. This means that we need to engage in a good deal of prayer before we get started. But if this is not possible just remember that the Holy Spirit is the unseen but indispensable guest at these encounters (John 3:1-8).

So let's step through the process of declaring the gospel to our unsaved friends.

1. We must tell them about themselves from the perspective of the bible. Number one fact is that he is a sinner and unable to change himself. He also needs to know that sin is against God and is, in essence, rebellion against Him. This brings with it the sentence of eternal death which he will serve in a place called hell. You mustn't tone this down as it is a critical step in the conversion process. It gives the sinner good reason to come to Christ, but don't be surprised if he disagrees with you at this stage.

2. We tell him about Christ; who Christ is, why he came, the meaning of his death, the significance of his resurrection, his session at the right hand of the Father, and his return. All of these things are important. Indeed, this is the heart of the gospel for the gospel is not about us and our experiences but about the Lord Jesus Christ and his saving work for lost sinners.

3. Finally we tell them what they must do in order to be saved, if they haven't done it already. They must acknowledge their guilt and need of forgiveness. They must turn to Christ for that forgiveness and accept his offer of salvation. To clarify: they must despair of their own efforts to save themselves and cast themselves completely and exclusively on Christ.

Now you might be thinking that this is a bit like baking a cake and in a way it is because there is a certain amount of unpredictability to it. Sticking to the recipe doesn’t guarantee success and it’s the same with the gospel. The reason for this is that it is ultimately up to the Holy Spirit to make it work. The parts that rely on the Holy Spirit are: (i) Consent to the truth of the gospel; (ii) Conviction of sin (against God) and the accompanying self-despair; (iii) exclusive trust in Jesus. But don’t be put off by this because you can also pray to the Holy Spirit. And remind yourself that where nothing is ventured, nothing is gained. The gospel is your friend’s ONLY hope of salvation. So give it a shot, and stop wasting your time on pre-evangelism. Rely on the Holy Spirit and may God bless your efforts. Amen.

9. How free is free?

The general reluctance to embrace Reformed particularism seems to be rooted in a perceived need to defend free will. After all, if election is unconditional then it is God who chooses us and we get no say in it at all. Do we have the power to repent and believe in Jesus all by ourselves? There are those who try to make it easy by removing the need for repentance. This is the position of having Jesus as Saviour and not as Lord. Now we only have belief to worry about. The trouble with that view is clearly stated in James 2:20, "Do you want to be shown, you foolish person, that faith apart from works is useless? "

So let’s return to the matter of free will. Just how free is it?

We could define free will as the power to do what one wants; so if the unbeliever hears the gospel and decides to ignore it we can conclude that he does not want what it offers him. He wills freely not to repent and believe in Christ and so the freedom of his will is preserved. But what about his want? Is the unbeliever free to want to repent and believe in Christ? Since “wants” (desires) come from the heart, and since the unregenerate heart is desperately wicked and humanly unknowable in its natural state (Jeremiah 17:9; Ezekiel 36:26) we would have to say “no” to this question. So while the unbeliever has free will, he does not have free want. And this is where the bonds of sin reside.

So how does the unbeliever gain the ability to want Christ? John 3:1-9 provides the answer. He must be “born again”. Note

from this passage that rebirth is the *condition* for entering the kingdom, not the result. And the fact that regeneration is sovereignly worked is clearly indicated by the words “the wind blows where it wills”. Our passivity in this process is also implied by the Greek word ‘gennethe’ - from ‘gennao’ - to be born (John 3:3), since we cannot birth ourselves.

The result of regeneration is a new nature even though the ability to sin remains. The Christian enters the new state described by the words “possible not to sin”. This implies that he is also able to sin, but is a far cry from his natural (unconverted) state of “not possible not to sin”. In short, we can now say that he has free want.

So how free is free? In respect to the will, we are free, but in respect to our wants, we are in bondage until set free in Christ.

10. Covid-19: A Christian perspective

I had to go shopping for groceries today and as I made my way through the isles of the supermarket I couldn't help noticing the complete absence of toilet paper. Just as well for me I didn't need it on that trip but I couldn't help asking myself what makes people react so irrationally in the midst of a national emergency such as the one we were then experiencing with COVID-19? If we had been warned of impending gastroenteritis or diarrhoea I could understand it but no such symptoms have ever been mentioned in connection with COVID-19. Clearly, the rush on toilet paper is an example of "panic buying", and panic makes people do irrational things. It is the fight or flight reaction where the blood drains from the head and concentrates in the muscles of the arms and legs. Why toilet paper? It could just as well have been dog food or toothpicks.

So where does the Christian fit into all this? Is there a place for panic in the Christian life? If there is then it needs to be compatible with the following verses:

1 Peter 5:6,7, "6 Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, 7 casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you."

Philippians 4:6,7, "6 do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let

your requests be made known to God. 7 And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus. ”

Luke 12:7, “Why, even the hairs of your head are all numbered. Fear not; you are of more value than many sparrows.

1 Peter 5:8, “Be sober minded; be watchful…”.

Matthew 10:28, “And do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell.”

I could have kept going but I think I have given enough references to prove beyond any doubt that the kind of panic we were witnessing in some people was totally incompatible with the Christian lifestyle as outlined in scripture. Does this mean that we are not to fear anything? Fear is one thing; panic is another. There is a healthy fear of a real and present danger that prepares us for action, but when that fear becomes uncontrolled we have crossed the biblical line and landed ourselves in the realm of insobriety and even foolishness.

So if we can agree that there is no place for panic in the Christian life does this mean that we can expect God to keep us and our loved ones safe from COVID-19? It depends on what you mean by “safe”. We know that nothing can separate us from the love of Christ (Romans 8:38-39). There is no guarantee anywhere in scripture that we will survive every illness, or car journey, or plane flight or any other activity we care to undertake. Indeed, we can die just as easily tucked safely in our beds. So the Christian’s protection from panic and

inordinate fear has nothing to do with staying well, or getting better. It does, however, have everything to do with the presence and protection of the One who has overcome sickness and death and who is able to deliver us not just FROM these things but also THROUGH them and OUT OF them.

This reminds me of those beautiful words of the apostle Paul in 2 Corinthians 5:8, “Yes, we are of good courage, and we would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord”. the apostle Paul preferred to be “dead” rather than alive because for him death was to be “at home with the Lord”. And how did this affect him? It gave him “good courage”.

So Christian, don’t fear COVID-19. Even it has a place in the eternal plan of God. Keep your eyes upon Jesus the Prince of Peace who delivers us from all these fears. And instead of being fearful,

> Rejoice in the Lord always; again I will say, rejoice. Let your reasonableness be known to everyone. The Lord is at hand; do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus. [Philippians 4:4-7]

11. Are natural disasters God's judgement upon sinners?

It is the conviction of some that the bush fires in Australia were a direct result of the wrath of God upon Australia for incorporating same-sex marriage into the marriage act. And forty years ago a similar connection was made between AIDS and homosexuality. So far we haven't heard anything about COVID-19 but I guess it's early days for that. The problem with all of these pronouncements is that many seemingly "innocent" people suffered from these disasters. I put the word "innocent" in inverted commas simply because, biblically, nobody is strictly innocent (See Romans 3:9-18). But, that notwithstanding, conservatively minded Christian families lost their homes in the bush fires. Babies and young children lost their lives to AIDS and the deaths from COVID-19 don't seem to be restricted to non-Christians. So why does God allow these disasters in the first place?

To begin to answer this question we need to go back to Genesis 3:17-19,

> 17 And to Adam he said, "Because you have listened to the voice of your wife and have eaten of the tree of which I commanded you, 'You shall not eat of it,' cursed is the ground because of you; in pain you shall eat of it all the days of your life; 18 thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you; and you shall eat the plants of the field. 19 By the sweat of your face you shall eat bread, till you return to

> the ground, for out of it you were taken; for you are dust, and to dust you shall return."

In the first instance we notice that God curses the "ground" because of Adam's sin. The consequences include an uncooperative earth which, instead of fruit and grain, wants to bring forth thorns and thistles. So Adam must work hard to make a living from the earth, and this hard work would eventually kill him.

What's important to notice here is that this curse upon the earth was not spontaneous but came directly from God as a result of Adam's sin. So why did God curse the earth? The answer is given to us in Romans 8:20, "For the creation was subjected to futility, not willingly, but because of him who subjected it, in hope." The key word here is "hope", i.e., an expectation of a better future. We conclude then that God did not want Adam and his descendants to be comfortable upon the earth but to be hopeful of a better one which he will create at the return of the Lord Jesus Christ.

So, returning to COVID-19, we know that COVID-19 is not the first pandemic to infect the world and neither will it be the last. Pandemics, insect plagues, cyclones, bushfires, earth quakes, floods and droughts are all manifestations of the curse which God himself placed upon the earth in order to direct our gaze away from the earth and toward his promises which alone can give us the ideal world we all so desperately seek.

Having established the nature and purpose of the Genesis curse we must acknowledge that, certainly in biblical times, God did use natural disasters to punish specific peoples for their sins.

The obvious ones were the universal flood and of course the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah. What is significant about these two is that we are told specifically why God sent these disasters. But there are also disasters recorded in the bible for which no explanation is given. The famines in the time of Abraham from which he escaped to Egypt for relief and the famine in the time of the patriarchs which resulted in their migration to Goshen. In the latter God not only saved the patriarchs but also the Egyptians despite their idolatrous practices.

So what can we conclude from the biblical examples? Clearly, God can use natural disasters to punish specific peoples but we have no warrant to read punishment into any specific case, particularly of certain peoples or races, unless God tells us as much. Again, Genesis 3:17-19 gives us the bottom line for all natural disasters: they are a natural part of a sin-cursed world and are to be expected no matter what moral state the world happens to be in.

Finally, it is easy for Christians to fall into the trap of condemning unbelievers for their sins and taking some satisfaction from their suffering where there is a clear connection between the two. But we must ask ourselves, is this the kind of attitude God wants us to have toward the unbeliever? If we have any understanding of sovereign grace at all we must be able to say, “There but for the grace of God go I”. If God had not kicked in the door of our hearts and invaded us with his Holy Spirit would we be any better? And what about the sins we continue to commit despite the spiritual resources he makes available to us? We have even less excuse.

So given the death rates of natural disasters such as COVID-19 we need to see them as wake-up calls to the church to reach out to the non-Christian world with greater urgency; and not just when disaster strikes but at all times. Let's not dwell on the possible causes; they are, at best, academic in the quest for souls and, at worst, plainly wrong when we try to connect them to specific sins and peoples without biblical warrant. We have a gospel of hope and hope is the real significance of the adversity we all have to suffer this side of eternity.

12. Whatever happened to repentance?

I guess we have all heard of the seeker sensitive service where great care is taken to avoid offending “seekers” in the congregation. One of the defining characteristics of such services is the substitution of the word “mistake” for the word “sin” and the absence of any exhortation to repentance; after all, why would you encourage repentance when people only make honest mistakes?

The aim in all this is to avoid giving new attendants a “negative” experience. But do we have a right to tone down sin and the need for repentance? It seems to me that filling the church with people has a higher priority here than building the church of the Lord Jesus Christ – and there is a difference. The true church is the body of Christ, put together by the Holy Spirit, who convicts people of their sin and leads them to Christ for forgiveness.

Because the Holy Spirit does not work in a vacuum, the gospel must facilitate the operation of these two vital components: conviction of sin and repentance if people are to undergo a valid and meaningful conversion. So what is repentance? The New Testament Greek word is “metanoia” (meta - a change; noia - the mind). So literally, repentance is a change of mind. We come to think differently about our sin. Before it didn’t worry us but now it does. Before we had no regrets about it but now we do. We could call this a change of attitude.

If we stopped here we would have to account for Judas whose sorrow for having betrayed Christ ended in his suicide along with eternal damnation. Clearly then, not all repentance results in salvation. The repentance we are exhorted to undergo in the gospel is a change of mind that results in an unbeliever turning FROM a life of sin and turning TO Christ for forgiveness. To understand this type of repentance let's turn to Acts 2:38.

> And Peter said to them, "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.

Peter has just finished charging his hearers with the crime of crucifying the Lord Jesus Christ (V.36). They did that because they hated him. Now they must love him. That is a big change and one that can only be brought about by the internal work of the Holy Spirit who works with the word in the transformation of hearts. So our hearers must hear about their sin. Peter did not shy away from charging his hearers with the world's worst crime. Neither did he hold back because of their seeker sensitivity. He gave it to them straight and so should we.

The repentance we undergo at the time of conversion is unique and therefore unrepeatable. It involves no less than a turning from a life of hating God to a life of loving him. We become his servants in Christ and we delight to serve him. Sure, we don't serve him perfectly but we become a work in progress which God promises to finish on the day of our death. This is not to say that repentance ceases to be a part of our spiritual lives after that, but that repentance is now quite different. It is a repentance from particular sin, confessed in prayer, preferably

on a daily basis, and coming from a heart of faith in and love toward God. It is not just a sorrow for having hurt others but primarily for having hurt God. This too needs to be encouraged from the pulpit.

So will we turn people away by preaching repentance? Quite possibly, but we will have done nothing more than the Lord Jesus Christ himself did when he told his hearers of the need to eat his flesh and drink his blood and almost emptied his church (John 6), or of what Stephen did when he accused his hearers of murdering the prophets (Acts 7). The gospel, when faithfully preached, will, by its very nature, discriminate between the sheep and the goats. But don’t be afraid, for we will be in good company; the very best. And will not the Holy Spirit build the church?

13. Being special to God

A Christian friend admitted to me that she had difficulty accepting God's love for her. My immediate response was, "But don't you believe that Jesus died for you on the cross?" Her response was immediate: "But he died for everybody". The problem for her was that if Jesus died for everybody and most people are not saved, just how big a deal is Jesus' death?

The question we need to answer is: can a universal atonement generate a life-changing love for Christ in the heart of the Christian. Before we write off universal atonement completely we must first consider those bible passages that seem to teach it. [All bible quotes are from the English Standard Version].

> 1 John 2:2 He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world.
>
> John 3:16 "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."
>
> 1 Timothy 2:5, 6 "For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all, which is the testimony given at the proper time."
>
> 1 Timothy 4:10 "For to this end we toil and strive, because we have our hope set on the living God,

> who is the Savior of all people, especially of those who believe."
>
> Hebrews 2:9 "But we see him who for a little while was made lower than the angels, namely Jesus, crowned with glory and honour because of the suffering of death, so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone."

All of these verses enable us to make a universal and genuine offer of salvation to all men and women without exception. They also teach that Jesus is the world's saviour, i.e., the only saviour by which anyone in the world can be saved. But we still haven't solved the problem of an apparent lack of particular or special love expressed in the death of Christ for individuals. In other words, where in the bible do we read of Jesus dying for me personally and not just for everybody in general in the hope that some might receive it? For a more in-depth treatment of this topic we turn to the story of the good shepherd in John 10.

In verse 3 Jesus tells us concerning the good shepherd, "The sheep hear his voice, and he calls his own sheep by name and leads them out." This clearly implies that there is a personal relationship between the good shepherd and his sheep. He doesn't call just any sheep, but only those which are "his". There is also the use of the personal possessive 'Idia' ("his own") which would be redundant if all sheep were his. So these sheep are special.

In verse 11 Jesus tells us "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep." We

know that these sheep are the same sheep of verse 3 so it is correct to say that the good shepherd lays down his life for *his* sheep.

As further proof of the fact that not all sheep belong to the good shepherd we read in verses 24-26 that the Jews who did not believe in him were “not among [his] sheep” (verse 26). Was this because of their disbelief? Let’s read verse 25, “but you do not believe because you are not among my sheep”. Here we see a cause and effect relationship between not being his sheep and not believing in him. If anyone had asked me, “How do I become one of Christ’s sheep” I would have answered, “by believing in him”. But this is not what Jesus says here. Again, let’s read the words carefully, …"you do not believe because you are not among my sheep". In other words not being one of his sheep is the CAUSE of which disbelief is the EFFECT. Conversely, being one of his sheep results in belief. This is made clear in verses 3-5.

So Jesus doesn’t tell us how to join his flock, at least not in this passage. He simply states that his sheep were given to him by his Father, know his voice, follow him, and are the reason for his death. So becoming the sheep of Christ predates belief. In fact it predates the cross for Jesus to be able to die for them. Does this solve the “nothing special” problem? Let's think about it.

What John 10 teaches us, among other things, is the particularism of the cross, i.e., Jesus dies for particular people and not for all people in general. It is called “particular redemption”. One of the tenants of Marxist communism is the supremacy of the state and the redundancy of the individual. In

other words, the individual is dispensable; only the state matters. Universal atonement has a similar problem. According to it Jesus dies for the masses but guarantees nothing for individuals. Within this paradigm nobody is special.

So how do we reconcile John 10 with the texts quoted earlier in support of universal atonement? We know that the bible, as the word of God, cannot contradict itself; so the texts must harmonise with John 10. Let me give a few suggestions on how this can be done.

1. God has given the world a saviour by whom all men and women can be saved.

2. A limited atonement does not limit the *atoning value* of the death of Jesus. In other words, it is not as though Jesus would have to suffer more in order to allow more into heaven. This makes his death sufficient for all and therefore infinitely valuable.

3. A death that is sufficient for all makes it possible to offer salvation to all conditional upon faith and repentance.

4. Nobody is held back from believing in Jesus. If a man or woman refuses to believe in Jesus it is because they love darkness (John 3:19-21), i.e., their own sin.

5. All who accept the free offer of the gospel are saved regardless of their ethnic, cultural or religious background.

So let us be clear: Jesus died for particular sinners; he died for his own sheep. We don’t make that true by believing it. It is

history and therefore immutable fact. And if you are a Christian, thank God! For he called you by name and you followed him.

We close with a quote from John Calvin.

> For until men recognise that they owe everything to God, that they are nourished by his fatherly care, that he is the Author of their every good, that they should seek nothing beyond him – they will never yield him willing service. Nay, unless they establish their complete happiness in him, they will never give themselves truly and sincerely to him. [John Calvin; Institutes of the Christian Religion, p.41. Pub. Library of Christian Classics].

14. The catastrophic consequences of Universal Atonement

I have commented on universal atonement (UA) in some of my previous posts but since writing them my opposition to UA has only strengthened to the point where I now believe that UA is not merely false in its assertion that Christ died for everybody but is actually catastrophic in its effect on the gospel and on systematic theology generally.

Am I being a bit extreme here? After all, most evangelical Christians hold to UA so can it be that harmful? I can only appeal to the foregoing logic and leave it to the reader to decide. It is possible to feel "right" about UA as it appeals to our natural sense of justice as well as a certain egalitarianism that we all like to attribute to God. The reasoning is simple: if God loves everybody equally then Jesus must have died for everybody. And if that is where our thinking stops it is no wonder that most Christians live and die holding fast to UA.

There are four good reasons why we must reject UA, the first of which is:

1. Universal Atonement amounts to double jeopardy.

When I speak of atonement I mean substitutionary atonement. When Christ died upon the cross he died for his people as their substitute. This death was not simply an example of sacrificial

love, contrary to the views of some, but an actual payment for sin, the penaty being death.

Most evangelicals who believe in UA are not universalists, i.e., they don't believe that everyone gets saved. This much the bible is quite clear on. But if we believe that not all for whom Christ died are actually saved then we have people in hell paying the penalty for their sin when Christ has already paid that penalty for them. This, in legal terms, is what is called "double jeopardy" pure and simple and it is patently unjust. If a friend pays your speeding fine for you, you will not be able to pay the fine yourself afterwards. The court will not accept it. So double jeopardy makes God unjust and the idea of an unjust God is itself catastrophic. Quad erat demonstrandum.

2. Universal atonement diminishes the saving power of Christ's death.

In their attempt to delimit the saving power of Christ's death, the advocates of UA actually diminish that power. If Christ went to the cross to save everybody and not everybody gets saved then his saving power is diminished exactly by the number of people who are not saved. Jesus tells us in Matthew 7:13-14 that only a few will be saved. It is safe to assume that the "few" here would be less than 50%. According to Wikipedia 23.1% of Australians were protestant as of 2016 and factoring in the very significant number of nominals would probably reduce that percentage to a single figure. And if we consider the global figure taking into account the non-Christian countries the figure attenuates even more. This makes the death

of Jesus considerably less than 10% successful. So why doesn't Jesus save everybody? The only answer is that he can't!

It is ironic that the attempt to magnify the saving power of Christ actually diminishes that power. Irrespective of what Christ's intentions were in going to the cross the effect, according to UA, was clearly not in his hands.

3. Universal Atonement divides the Trinity

John 10 makes it very plain that the death of Christ was no divine afterthought. Jesus tells us that it was the Father who gave him the sheep for whom he came. And in Ephesians 2 we are told that this transaction took place "before the foundation of the world". We know from other parts of scripture, and in particular the gospels, that Jesus came to do the Father's will. He was not a free spirit to do whatever he liked.

This clearly points to a plan, drawn up by the Father and executed by the Son. Part of that execution was the death of the Son for his sheep. It is not rocket science to see that the sheep for whom Jesus died were the sheep given to him by the Father in eternity. UA utterly destroys that plan. Let me explain.

According to UA, Jesus goes to the cross to die for everybody. His death is completely indiscriminate in its purpose. In doing this Jesus departs from the Father's plan and now constructs his own. What we have here is a division within the Trinity itself. We have one plan of the Father and another of the Son, and they are not compatible.

I cannot begin to describe the catastrophic effect of this debacle on Christian theology. One possible way out is to invoke a bit of Christology by suggesting that it was the human will of Christ to die for everyone while his divine will remained unchanged. But this constitutes a serious cleavage between the divine and human natures of Christ. We know that at Gethsemane the human and divine wills of Christ were in tension but his prayer ended with the words, "Nevertheless, not my will but yours be done" (Luke 42). Jesus always deferred to the Father. That was his righteousness which we depend on for our justification.

So any decision to deviate from the Father's plan would disqualify Jesus as a saviour. He would cease to be the unblemished lamb and could not even save himself. We know, of course, that this is impossible, but the consequences of UA must be stated clearly.

4. Universal Atonement leads to a false gospel.

The false gospel I refer to is the one we are all familiar with. It is the call to "believe that Jesus died for your sins". So what's wrong with that? Nowhere in the New Testament is anyone called to believe that Jesus died for their sins. And yet, if we believe that Jesus died for everyone then it is inevitable that we will end up defining the gospel in such terms., But just how good is that gospel? Not so good when we consider how many are actually saved. But now let's consider exactly what this gospel asks people to do.

In telling people that Jesus has died for their sins we are stating a proposition. But saving faith is not a belief in a proposition.

John 3:16 tells us that it is those who believe *in* Jesus (*eis* - to, into) who are saved. To believe certain things about Jesus is to believe no more than what the demons believe, but to believe *in* Jesus is to trust him to do what he undertakes. This implies a personal relationship with Jesus and is the response called for in the gospel.

The gospel then is a call to a personal relationship with Jesus based on his person and work which are integral to the gospel. This call can never be reduced to a simple proposition. To call this proposition a false gospel might sound a bit harsh but it is a far cry from the gospel of the New Testament, and in fact, may not even be true for the person we are addressing. Nobody can say that Jesus died for them until they put their faith in Jesus for salvation. It is only then that they can know such a thing.

I have attempted to show that the doctrine of UA is no minor deviation from Christian orthodoxy but actually quite catastrophic in its effect upon Christian theology. So what is the alternative? clearly there can only be a limited atonement; not limited in power but in purpose. The question is: what was Christ's purpose in going to the cross? The answer is to save those whom the Father gave him before the foundation of world. And at this he was 100% successful. This makes his death a clear beacon of hope and assurance for the Christian.

15. Election

Election is like a man whose house is infested with cockroaches. Because he has a deep respect for living things he tries to put up with the insects but when they start crawling over him in bed at night he finally cracks and decides to call the pest man. On the day the pest man is due he decides to save some of the cockroaches. He manages to catch ten of them, placing them in a cardboard box and releasing them into a vacant allotment some distance from his house. The house is subsequently sprayed and the rest of the cockroaches are killed.

There is nothing remarkable about calling in the pest man to kill cockroaches but what is remarkable about this story is that the house owner bothers to save ten of them. “Why”, we would ask, “would anyone bother to save ten cockroaches?

Now let’s compare this story with Divine Election. In John 10 Jesus makes it clear that he came to save those whom the Father gave him. This is explicit in Ephesians 1:4 where the apostle Paul tells us that “He [God] chose us in him [Christ] before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight” (brackets mine). So what do we find remarkable about this story? If your answer consists in not choosing everybody you would be right, which is the reverse of what we found in the first story, namely, that the home owner chose to save some. So what makes them different?

In the first story we are talking about cockroaches which most people find detestable. For us it is no big deal to kill a hundred cockroaches. In the second story we are talking about people. And to be a little more descriptive, sinners. In our eyes they are just like us and could even be our next door neighbour. But what are they like in God’s eyes? For that we must turn to Ephesians 2:1-3 and Romans 3:10-18. The scary thing about these verses is that they describe everybody not in Christ. God’s perspective is of one who is incomprehensibly holy and for whom sin is detestable.

If we allow these descriptions to sink in we will begin to see that the cockroach story is not a lot different from the election story. In both we should marvel at the fact that some, albeit a minority, are actually saved. Unsaved sinners are no less deserving of condemnation than cockroaches are of total destruction. Their sin is just as detestable in God's sight as cockroaches are in ours.

16. Overcoming the sinful nature

You don't have to be a Christian for long to hear about the sinful nature. So what exactly is it? We know that it is a "nature", i.e., a property of living beings that determines their behaviour. Take, for example, the cat. If you want an animal to take for a walk you would not get a cat. Why not? Because most cats (there is always the exception!) don't want to walk with their owners. The cat will happily walk on its own but not with you, and especially not on a leash. The RSPCA advises against walking cats on a leash. And if you are not convinced just take a walk on any late afternoon and you will see plenty of people walking their dogs but you won't see anyone walking their cat. And it is not as though the cat can't walk; it can. But the cat is, unlike a dog, not a pack animal but hunts alone using stealth to catch its prey.

So when we do things by nature we do what comes naturally. Any specific behaviour must be a natural function of who and what we are and there are only so many possibilities. For the unbeliever, the sinful nature is also limited by what it can do. It can do many noble things such as acts of heroism, generosity, compassion, love, kindness, patience …etc. But despite all of these things we know from scripture that there is one thing it cannot do: it cannot love God. It is, in fact, quite opposed to God and wants nothing to do with him. Romans 3:10 and 18 say, "no one understands; no one seeks for God…There is no fear of God before their eyes". We get a similarly bleak picture from John 3:19-20.

So how does the unbeliever ever manage to come to Christ? How does he repent and believe? Clearly, he needs a change of nature. Let me illustrate: a cat owner complains to a friend that he cannot get his cat to walk with him. “I’ve tried everything”, he says. “I’ve even planted cat food at various places along the way, but to no avail”. His friend, a dog owner, says to him, “If you want an animal to walk with you try getting a dog.” We could put this another way: if you want your cat to walk with you try rebirthing it as a dog. Now that sounds ridiculous but it’s really not that far from the truth, and it was spot on the truth when Jesus told Nicodemus in John 3:1 ff that if he wanted to enter the Kingdom of God he would have to be born again, not of sinful parents but of water and the Spirit.

So we must not underestimate the radical nature of the change that the Holy Spirit brings about inside of us to enable us to embrace Christ in the gospel. Until this change takes place we *cannot* come. We call this a moral inability as opposed to a physical inability.

This raises an important question: just as we cannot blame a cat for not wanting to walk with us, should we not blame an unbeliever for not wanting to walk with Christ? This is where our cat analogy breaks down for the cat is not a moral agent; it has no covenantal responsibility to God and cannot even conceive of such a responsibility. Man, on the other hand, is a moral agent having been created in the image of God. Man can understand what his responsibility is toward God which is why he wants nothing to do with God. He suppresses the truth of God in unrighteousness (Romans 1:18) because that truth is inconvenient to him.

The bottom line here is that unregenerate man's reason for refusing Christ in the gospel is not because he wants to accept Christ but can't. The problem is that he never wants Christ. His inability is not in the structure of his brain or the anatomy of his body (like the cat) but in the condition of his heart and his heart is the source of his wants. It is the heart that is changed in regeneration and this is what it means to be born again.

17. Reconciling a gracious God with an eternal hell

Eventually the doctrine of hell must come up in any serious discussion of the gospel. According to Michael Allen Rogers, Senior Pastor, WPC, Lancaster Pennsylvania, …"no Bible spokesman places more stress on hell as the final consequence of God's judgement of condemnation than Jesus. God's Son was the great theologian of hell."[1]

So we ignore this subject at our own peril. But the question I want to focus on in this chapter is: how do we reconcile the idea of a gracious God with that of an eternal hell? Surely there has to be a limit to the amount of punishment the sinner has to bear!

There are three things we can deduce about hell from what we know about God.

First We know that God is just. As Abraham asks rhetorically in Genesis 18:25, …"Shall not the Judge of all the earth do what is just?". And the answer, of course, is YES! So we know that eternal suffering in hell is just. It may not seem to be just but we accept by faith that it is.

Second Since justice demands that punishment be in proportion to the crime the condition of those in hell must be bad enough to warrant the punishment of hell.

1www.crossway.org/articles/what-did-jesus-teach-about-hell/

Third The eternal duration of hell means that this condition never changes. There will never be righteous people in hell.

So let's unpack that a little. Is it possible that because of the agony of hell lost souls may begin to feel genuine sorrow for the sins that put them there? We can answer this question by considering the kind of change that would be needed to bring that about. It is the same change that is needed to bring sinners to a genuine sorrow for their sins on earth. From John 3 we learn that spiritual regeneration (rebirth) is required to enable us to repent and believe in Christ. The repentance that is a result of regeneration is not merely a sorrow for the consequences of our sin but a sorrow for having offended God.

It is this Godward component that distinguishes true gospel repentance from worldly repentance. So for the lost souls in hell regeneration must precede any true gospel repentance, i.e., they must be born again. But because hell is a place bereft of any supernatural or natural grace from God (See Matthew 8:12-13 et al.) the gospel simply isn't preached there (Hebrews 3:7-19).

The obvious consequence of this spiritual immutability that never ends is a punitive hell that never ends. So the eternity of hell is entirely consistent with the eternity of unrepentance on the part of its occupants. They never change their attitude toward God. This is not to say that they like being in hell. Jesus tells us that hell is a place of "weeping and gnashing of teeth" (Matthew 8:12 et al.). But neither would they like being in heaven as in heaven they would find themselves face to face with God, which is every unbeliever's worst nightmare! (Hebrews 10:31).

So what I have said thus far about hell may not eliminate all the discomfort most of us feel about it, but it should obviate the need, felt by some, to marginalise this doctrine in the interest of grace. It is a doctrine we must live with by faith, just as we must live with the tension between divine sovereignty and human responsibility. But now there is an upside to all of this.

Let me now show how such a sobering doctrine can actually contribute to our appreciation of the saving grace of God. The gospel is only good news when we appreciate the bad news. The bad news is that hell is eternal and we all deserve to be there. The good news is that Christ suffered hell on the cross at Calvary for all who come to him in faith and repentance. We, for whom Christ died, are no less deserving of eternal hell than the tortured souls who live there. So the doctrine of eternal hell is the backdrop to the infinite and eternal love of Christ for his people. What deep and abiding gratitude we should have as a consequence of being saved from such a place! What a profound sense of divine grace we should have when we contemplate the horrors from which Christ has rescued us! And how urgent does the gospel become when we consider the plight of those outside of the church!

We close with a quote from the famous hymn "It Wasn't the Nails" by Bishop Rudolph McKissick Sr.

“Oh it wasn't the nails that held Him to the cross,
He could have come down,
But the whole world would be lost.
For God so loved the world,
That He gave His only Son,
No greater love had been given to anyone.”

About the Author

Charlie Cornford is a graduate of the Reformed Theological College, Geelong, Victoria, Australia and holds the degree of Bachelor of Divinity with Distinction. He has 37 years of

preaching experience, plays jazz on clarinet, sax and flute and currently lives with his wife Liz in Bellmere, Queensland, Australia.